

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Turning Over Tables:
A Lenten Call for Disrupting Power
Easter Sunday ~ Embody*

April 20th, 2025



Sun in the Park, by Jens Ferdinand, 1904

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Easter Improvisation

Toccata and Fugue in D minor 'Dorian', BWV 538 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Toccata and Fugue in F, BWV 540 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering for Palm Sunday

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack & Rev. Lehman

from the Gospel of Mark, Chapter 11

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Easter Processional

***Easter Processional**

Christ the Lord is Risen Today

EASTER HYMN

Christ the Lord is risen today, Alleluia!

Mortal tongues and angels say: Alleluia!

Raise your joys and triumphs high, Alleluia!

Sing, glad heavens, and earth reply: Alleluia!

Let the Victor's people sing, Alleluia!

Where, O death, is now thy sting? Alleluia!

Dying once, Christ lives to save, Alleluia!

Where your victory, O grave? Alleluia!

Love's redeeming work is done, Alleluia!

Fought the fight, the battle won, Alleluia!

Death in vain forbids Christ rise, Alleluia!

God has opened paradise, Alleluia!

Soar we now where Christ has led, Alleluia!

Following our exalted Head, Alleluia!

Made like Christ, like Christ we rise, Alleluia!

Ours the cross, the grave, the skies, Alleluia!

***Easter Words of Gathering and Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

This is the place and this is the time.

Today, we see the world and the whole of life in a new light.

*We see so that we might be filled with hope,
and joy for the future.*

This is the place, as are all places:

This is the time, as are all times.

Here and now.

*This is the place and this is the time
where all are welcomed - where all are loved.*

Holy One, today we celebrate the Spirit of life over death.
We light the Christ Candle, aware that the power of resurrection
has forever changed who we can become,
and has given us the courage to boldly proclaim
we are all the children of the Living God.

Here and now we celebrate:
new life,
new joy,
new possibilities.
*We give thanks for the Spirit of Life
visible in Jesus,
visible in us,
visible in all people!*

And we pray, O God,
that it may ever be so.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Alleluia"

EURYDICE OSTERMAN

Laude, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*

John Philip Newell

Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Easter Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

We believe in the exquisite nature of each individual.
*Peace to the people who respect their challenging
and exciting friends and neighbors!*

We believe in justice for all people.

Peace to the people who support the right for people to be accepted for who they are!

We believe in the acceptance of people of whatever race, creed, cultural background, sexual orientation and gender identity and expression.

Peace to the people who speak out against discrimination, persecution, bullying, verbal and physical abuse of individuals and groups!

We believe in an Inclusive Church.

Peace to the people, who, with their love and desire for wholeness of humankind, create communities and churches where we are empowered to worship in the spirit of diversity, honesty, and love... just as we are!

[adapt/gduncan]

On this Easter morning,
may the heart of peace be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Easter Children's Conversation

Claire Kelly

Following this conversation, children are invited to join us for our Easter Festival which will be followed by our Egg Hunts. If you were unable to check your child/ren in prior to the service, please accompany them to our registration table and check them in before returning to the service. Parents, after service please follow signs according to your child's age group and join them at their age designated Egg Hunt. Immediately following the Egg Hunt, please join us at our Easter Brunch where you will find refreshments and a photo backdrop!

The Reading from the Gospel *from the Gospel of Matthew*

Lance & Brittany Skiles

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Rev. Fregin

Gathered here on this Easter morning,
we feel our hearts stretching toward new beginnings.
On this day we remember our hopes and our dreams,
we reflect on who we are and the ways our hearts
need to change in order to affirm our deepest aspirations.

In the holy quietness of this place we come:
seeking peace and the quiet serenity born of insight,
seeking beauty in the inner sanctuary of the sounds and sights of our lives,
seeking courage, and the fortitude to live our own lives.

On this Easter morning,
we come striving to be open to this incredible life
that calls us forth from old ways of being
into new ways of embracing the new life,
God offers to each and everyone one of us.

Silence

Prayers of Our Hearts Expressed through the Lighting of Candles

Lance & Brittany Skiles

When Jesus saw the crowds, he went up on the mountainside, and after he sat down and the disciples had gathered around, Jesus began to teach them:

“Blessed are those who are poor in spirit:
the kingdom of heaven is theirs.

*Blessed are those who are mourning:
they will be consoled.*

Blessed are those who are gentle:
they will inherit the land.

*Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for justice:
they will have their fill.*

Blessed are those who show mercy to others:
they will be shown mercy.

*Blessed are those whose hearts are clean:
they will see God.*

Blessed are those who work for peace:
they will be called children of God.

*Blessed are those who are persecuted
because of their struggle for justice:
the kingdom of heaven is theirs.*

“You are fortunate when others insult you and persecute you, and utter every kind of slander against you because of me. Be glad and rejoice, for you will help to bring heaven to earth as you honor the ancestors who have gone before us.”

Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

“The Beatitudes”

H.R. EVANS

Cathedral Choir, Lorenzo Zapata, Soloist

Sermon

Embody

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Lance & Brittany Skiles

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

“Joy Never Leaves”

CHRISTOPHER HARRIS

Cathedral Choir, Dr. David Harris, Director

"I am full of tears!! Tears of joy that seem to well and flow upon the thought that I carry the promise of beauty for ashes and life anew. A plan so delicate that no gentle hand of ours could place it all in place with grace to cause it not to break. Birthed from faith and made with love, it grows. Hope nurtures it and peace sustains the dwelling place as the hymn does the soul that sings of Thee. These tears which once fell for loss, now build a grateful river that runs through forests of prayer and possibility. They flow, but joy never leaves." ~Devondra Banks

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Lance & Brittany Skiles

Spirit of Liberation and Life, determined and gracious,
through these gifts, teach us of loyalty to love's ways.
May we become more committed to each other's flourishing.
May we be released from fears that cause us to hoard resources, power, and control.
May we become convinced of the power you have given us to disrupt, resist, and transform our
world through loving intention, commitment, and peace.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Beatitudes Remix from enfleshed

Ministers & Cathedral Choir

blessed are you who are raging.
blessed are you who are mourning.
blessed are you who feel numb.
blessed are you who feel sick. and tired. and sick and tired.

blessed are you who refuse to turn away.
blessed are you who need to turn away.
blessed are you who keep breathing deep.
blessed are you who are tending to your own needs.
blessed are you who are tending to the needs of another.

blessed are you who have been calling.
blessed are you who have been organizing.
blessed are you who have been testifying.
blessed are you who have been hearing.
blessed are you who have been resisting.

blessed are you who feel broken open beyond repair.
blessed are you who are raw beyond words.

blessed are you who are working hotlines and crisis care centers
and bearing witness to the forces of violence and trauma unleashed and unloosed.
blessed are you who are marching.
blessed are you who are weeping.

blessed are you who preach and know that divinity resides
in despised, abused, violated flesh.
blessed are you who know deep in your bones that we are all good. and beautiful.
and beloved. and sacred. and worthy. and believed. and held. and capable of healing
beyond our wildest imagination.

blessed are you who remind others they are good. and beautiful. and beloved. and sacred. and
worthy. and believed. and held. and capable of healing beyond their wildest imagination.

*blessed are we when we dare to dream of a world without sexual violence,
without white supremacy, without misogyny, without police brutality,
without anti-trans and anti-queer violence.
blessed are we when we stay tender.
blessed are we when we stay fierce.
blessed are we when we dare to imagine repair, and transformation.
blessed are we when we labor together to make it so.*

Rev. Anna Blaedel

Hallelujah Amen!

Choral Response

"Hallelujah Chorus"

G.F. HANDEL

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Conductor*

*Easter Hymn for the Journey *Celebrate a New Day Dawning*

HYMN TO JOY

Celebrate a new day dawning,
Sunrise of a golden morn;
Christ our Savior dwells among us,
Glorious visions now are born.
Equal partners 'round the table,
We make dreams reality;
Calling out our gifts we nurture
Hope beyond all we can see.

Christ our Savior lights the pathway
To a world of harmony;
All our siblings' love surrounds us,
Nourishing our synergy.
Earth joins in our rich communion,
Grateful for our healing care;
Leaping deer and soaring eagles,
All Earth's fullness now can share.

Sing a song of jubilation,
Dance with joyous revelry;
Clapping trees and laughing rivers
Join our call to liberty.

Freed at last to blossom fully,
Flowering forth in beauty bright,
We become a new creation,
Bursting open into light.

- lyrics adapted from Jann Aldredge-Clanton

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Toccata from *Symphony No. 5* (Charles-Marie Widor)

Inside The Music

"I discovered contemporary composer Christopher Harris and his new piece "Joy Never Leaves," set to a poem by Devondra Banks, a few months ago. I immediately thought of it for the end of this series, and as an Easter celebration during the complicated moment we're living through. Banks specifically writes about embodying emotion and experience. The central experience of weeping holds space for life's complexity in her poem. Joy and sorrow, life and ashes, gentle hands, birthing, nurturing, and other lived experiences enter our minds through the embodying energy of tears. At the core of her poem is "a plan so delicate." This metaphoric reflection on existence refers to the duality of individual experience and integrated experience with all things. What we feel individually, what we embody, is an extension, perhaps a linkage, to the vastness of creation. Harris creates ample space for Banks' words to land. He gives the choir long lines full of big singing and to the organ he gives power and articulation. From the first note to the last we are invited to feel these words deep inside us, to embody them. He regularly returns to the opening motive that accompanies the "tears" text. Although the words change upon each repetition, we are brought back to the memory of this distinct form of embodiment. We are encouraged to feel the essence of our being changing with each repetition. Or, in Banks' words: "These tears which once fell for loss, now build a grateful river that runs through forests of prayer and possibility. They flow, but joy never leaves." H.R. Evans, like Harris, takes a complicated, concept-rich text, and makes musical space around it for our ears to hear it anew. Both composers use harmonic shifts and recontextualizing to enrich the electricity around each new phrase. Evan's setting of The Beatitudes relies at first on a soloist and choral response. We are treated to the dramatic image of Jesus proclaiming these truths with the choir backing him up. Yet, unlike in the original story, the choir finishes his sentences. Dramatically, we are all a part of giving voice to humanity's deepest truths. Of particular interest to me is the moment when the text says "blessed are you when others persecute you, and say all manner of evil against you falsely." We live in a time when people in power make a daily display of how easy it is to slander or disrupt people's lives. Evans, living in the early 20th century, knew the life-altering potential of slander. He grew up impoverished in an overlooked part of Wales, and rose to prominence in the posh English musical world through his passion and grass-roots insistence on a deep love of music and belief that all people should have access to it. The music in this section gets quiet and slow, with the choir's phrases punctuated by death chimes. It is a warning for those who would heed, and a motivation to strive for equal justice. And then the music breaks into a celebratory fugue that calls us into joy. "Rejoice and be exceedingly glad," we sing in canon, for the rewards of this life cannot be measured against that which we can discover more deeply. The Beatitudes articulate the complexities of living in human community. It gives a hopeful outline of ways we can learn to grow together for the sake of all people. Evans surrounds this hope with music that wraps each phrase in dramatic context so that we might sink into its promise and find life anew." -Dr. David Harris